



WIRED FOR SENSORY: UNDERSTANDING YOUR ADHD TWEEN & TEEN'S UNIQUE SENSES

Practical OT strategies to harness their
senses and unlock calm, focus and
confidence.

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I am an occupational therapist, a mum and ADHDer. Although I was diagnosed as a child, I spent years drifting in and out of self-doubt, anxiety, and shame, always sensing I couldn't quite fit with the norm. It took me until I hit full-swing mum and wife mode — navigating sleep deprivation, hormonal shifts and endless to-dos — to see my everyday struggles as part of my ADHD story.

Only in the last few years have I started connecting with this part of myself. With this new level of understanding, I have rebuilt my self-worth and discovered more clarity as a woman, mum and OT.

Now, I combine lived experience with professional tools to offer judgment-free support to women and girls with ADHD — sparking connection, self-acceptance, and growth.

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REGULATION FIRST. LEARNING FOLLOWS.

Every tween or teen's brain is wired a little differently, and that's a good thing. One of the most powerful ways to support a teen's regulation, organisation and learning isn't more willpower. It's often about adjusting the conditions around them to meet their unique brain where it's at.

The truth is, a teen can try every learning hack in the book, but if they're in fight-or-flight mode and irritated by the tag in their shirt, the flickering desk lamp, or the sound of pots clanging in the kitchen, their brain isn't in a state to learn or listen effectively. They're not just distracted; their nervous system is overstimulated. No amount of flashcards or timers will fix that.

The opposite can also be true. Some teens feel understimulated (sluggish, flat, spaced out), especially after school or extended screen time. These teens may need to dial up their sensory input — louder music, bigger movement, brighter lights, chewing gum, a standing desk or a sensory “wake-up” tool like a mini trampoline or an ice-cold drink.



Every nervous system is different. The key is helping your child find their own regulated zone - not too wired or flat - just right for the task at hand. Sometimes that means being calm and focused for homework. Other times, it means having enough energy to jump on the trampoline with their little brother.

This guide will help you:

- Understand your tween or teens sensory preferences
- Use sensory tools and supports to adjust their environment to suit their brain
- Build interoceptive awareness to support internal self-regulation
- Support daily routines, transitions and learning times at home

This isn't about "fixing" your child. It's about creating the conditions that match how their brain works best, and adjusting your approach so their nervous system is ready for whatever the day brings.



DISCOVER THEIR SENSORY PREFERENCES

The way their brain takes in the world shapes how they learn.

Why it works:

When your teen begins to understand how sensory information, such as light, sound, touch, smell, and movement, affects their focus and mood, they can start to adjust their environment to support regulation, rather than just pushing through overwhelm.

When we talk about sensation, there are 8 main senses:

- Vision (sight)
- Auditory (sound)
- Tactile (touch)
- Oral/gustatory (taste)
- Olfactory (smell)
- Proprioception (body awareness through muscles and joints)
- Vestibular (balance and movement, based in the inner ear)
- Interoception (internal cues like hunger, thirst or fatigue)

Research insight:

Sensory processing plays a major role in self-regulation and attention. According to Sensory Integration Theory, recognising and supporting sensory preferences can reduce anxiety, improve attention, and boost learning, especially in neurodivergent learners.

How to support your teen's sensory discovery:

Start with curiosity. First, ask yourself:

- "What sensory experiences does my teen naturally seek?"
- "What sensory experiences does my teen usually avoid?"

Then ask:

- "What sensory input can we increase to help them feel more regulated for the task at hand?"
- "What sensory input can we decrease to help them feel more regulated for the task at hand?"

Invite your teen to notice what sensations feel good and which don't, in different environments.

Try asking questions like:

- “During homework, do you focus better when it’s quiet or with soft music?”
- “Does sitting still make it harder or easier to think clearly?”
- “Does it help you to listen if you are able to hold a fidget?”
- “What helps your brain feel energised before getting ready for school?”

Let them know it’s okay to need things that others don’t; lying on the floor to study, using a wobble stool, or doing chores with noise-cancelling headphones aren’t indulgences. They’re regulation strategies.

Try this:

- **Observe and respect their cues** – Notice when your teen or tween fidgets, stretches, yawns, zones out or shuts down. They’re signals that their nervous system is seeking regulation.
- **Create opportunities to meet their unique sensory needs** – Let them experiment and choose their own strategies or tools, even if it’s not what you’d personally prefer.
- **Reach out for a more detailed analysis** - Work with an Occupational Therapist to complete a Sensory Processing Assessment and in-depth interview.



Neuro Nugget:

Deep pressure and heavy work activities send powerful input to the body's proprioceptive system (the sense that tells the brain where the body is in space). This input calms the central nervous system, helps regulate emotions and can improve focus and body awareness. It's like giving the nervous system a snug hug from the inside.

Try incorporating simple heavy work into daily life:

- Push-ups against the wall or floor
- Carrying shopping bags or laundry baskets
- Play wrestling with a sibling or roughhousing with a pet
- Vacuuming, raking or dragging the bin out on bin night
- Using a weighted lap sash during homework or wind-down time
- Swimming, martial arts or team sports

If sensory differences are impacting your tween or teen's daily life at home, school or socially, consider connecting with a paediatric occupational therapist for tailored support.

Real-Life Story:

Let's call her Sarah — a Year 9 student who avoided homework like the plague. She would fidget, wander, and suddenly remember a dozen "urgent" tasks before picking up a pencil.

After exploring her sensory preferences, her mum discovered she was sensitive to visual clutter, focused better with background sound, and needed movement to stay engaged during seated tasks. She did a \$20 Kmart blitz — a few trays, a document sorter, and a desk organiser.

We added regular movement breaks between short focus blocks. Sometimes on a wobble cushion, sometimes standing and swaying, other times lying on the floor. Calming ocean sounds played in the background. Clearing the clutter and honouring her sensory preferences made a big difference. Homework became far less of a battle.

CREATE A SENSORY-FRIENDLY ENVIRONMENT

Sensory-friendly environments support calm, focus and follow-through

Why it works:

The right physical environment can help your teen feel calmer and more focused. When we reduce sensory overload and remove unnecessary mental clutter, we conserve the brain's energy for the task at hand.

Sensory-friendly spaces also support nervous system regulation, helping the brain shift out of "stress mode" and into a state where positive habits and learning are more likely to stick.

Research insight:

Environmental factors, such as lighting, sound, layout, and sensory load, significantly impact a teenager's ability to focus and self-regulate. The Clever Classrooms study found that physical learning environments account for up to 16% of variation in academic performance, especially when tailored for calmness, comfort and clarity. The more we reduce distractions, the more we support the prefrontal cortex (the brain's planning and focus hub) over the amygdala (the stress and threat system).

Parent tip:

Help them focus on what helps their brain, not what looks good on social media. Involve your teen in organising their bedroom and study space so it reflects what they find calming, comfortable and supportive. Think function over aesthetics and keep regulation at the centre.



Try this:

- **Declutter their space together** – Keep surfaces clear, hide cords and use baskets, trays, document holders or drawers to reduce visual clutter. A visually uncluttered space helps the brain settle, whether it's time to do homework, pack a bag or wind down for bed.
- **Use light to support transitions** – Natural light works well for energy and focus. In the evenings, soft, warm lamps can help with calming and winding down. Remove flickering bulbs or overly bright lights that may be overstimulating. Experiment with colour-changing light bulbs.
- **Adjust sound based on what the task needs** – Use background music, calming nature sounds, binaural beats or noise-cancelling headphones depending on whether your teen needs focus, motivation or calm.
- **Offer flexible seating options** – Wobble cushions, standing desks, textured floor mats, or a cosy beanbag can help your teen engage with chores, reading or homework in ways that suit their sensory system.
- **Use scent as a gentle cue** – Scents like peppermint or citrus can help energise and cue a transition into a task. Lavender or chamomile may support bedtime wind-down. Try using a diffuser or essential oil on a cotton pad as a cue for routines.
- **Add extra tactile sensations** – Use fidget tools (like stress balls, putty, sensory stones or spinners) or textured materials (felt desk strips, body brushes, soft blankets). Fidget toys on a keyring are great to attach to pencil cases to use during class.
- **Experiment with temperature** – A cold drink, an ice pack on the neck, or a warm wheat bag on the lap can provide grounding sensory input and support regulation during challenging or slow-to-start tasks.
- **Engage taste to support focus** – Chewy or crunchy snacks (like dried fruit, jerky, raw carrots or apples) offer organising input for the brain. Sugar-free gum or mints can help maintain alertness and focus. Add lemon or mint to water for a refreshing sensory boost.

TUNE INTO INTEROCEPTION

Helping your teen understand their body's inner signals

Why it works:

Interoception is the sense that helps us notice and understand what's happening inside our body. Things like hunger, thirst, needing the toilet, or feeling tired, anxious, excited, or in pain.

For some teens, these internal signals can be harder to notice or interpret. They might not realise what their body needs until the feeling becomes intense, which can lead to overwhelm, emotional outbursts, or behaviour that's misunderstood.

Supporting your teen to tune into these cues in safe, gentle ways is a powerful way to strengthen their self-awareness, and to show them that their body signals are valid and worth listening to.

Research Insight:

Emerging research in neuroscience and occupational therapy suggests that strong interoceptive awareness is associated with improved emotional regulation and self-awareness. When teens can read their body's cues, they're more equipped to manage anxiety, self-advocate, and take proactive steps toward regulation.



Try this:

- **Name the feeling and the body signal** – Help your teen link emotions to body cues: "Your hands are clenched, maybe your body's telling you it's tense or frustrated?."
- **Try a body check-in together** – Ask: "What's your heart doing? Your breathing? Do you feel full or hungry?"
- **Practice with metaphors** – Use visual scales or weather metaphors: "Are you feeling like a thunderstorm or more like a light breeze today?"
- **Use interoceptive pauses** – Before a task, ask: "What does your body need right now to feel more ready?"
- **Model your own awareness out loud** – "I'm starting to get cranky. I think my blood sugar is low. I'm going to grab a snack."

Helping your teen build interoceptive awareness takes time, but every small step improves their ability to pause, reflect and self-regulate from the inside out.



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